



PTI

DELHI | Power from the Son

It was Rahul Gandhi who turned Kalavati, an impoverished widow living in a Maharashtrian village that gets little electricity, into a national identity. The Congress general secretary invoked Kalavati's woes while pitching for the nuclear deal in 2008, saying that the deal would bring electricity to Kalavati's doorstep. Nuclear power is still a long way off but environmental group Greenpeace has zeroed in on Kalavati's village, Jalka, and set up solar panels that power 10 fans and a laptop in a school. Their message: it will take nuclear energy 20 years to empower Kalavati's village but solar energy took three days. Electricity came to Kalavati's village in the 1980s, but as Rahul pointed out, the erratic power supply is only for a few hours. Not surprisingly, the CPI(M) leapt into the frame, being the first to applaud this move. Brinda Karat was snappy on the soundbyte: "Renewable energy is the best way to give energy security to crores of Kalavatis. The import of costly nuclear plants will make India energy-insecure." For their part, Greenpeace chose Jalka because, according to Vinuta Gopal, manager, Climate and Energy Campaign, Kalavati had become "a representative of energy security" since Rahul *baba* introduced her to India. For the time being, it's more power to Kalavati. *by Priya Sahgal*

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RAHUL GANDHI
(TOP) AND
KALAVATI

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days is the time it took for solar power to be functional in Jalka village, home to Kalavati, the Maharashtra widow made famous by Rahul Gandhi in Parliament.